

Scholarly Articles on Myth in Ancient Society (HUM101 Midterm Essay Q1)

Myth as Justification for Societal Ideas

- **H. G. Baynes (1936)** – *On the Psychological Origins of Divine Kingship*. <https://www.jstor.org/stable/1257343> – **Theme 1:** Explores how the concept of **divine kingship** functions psychologically, illustrating myth used to legitimize a ruler's authority in society.
- **D. Howard Smith (1957)** – *Divine Kingship in Ancient China*. <https://www.jstor.org/stable/3269343> – **Theme 1:** A case study of **divine kingship in China**, showing mythological justification of the emperor's semi-divine status as a foundation for social and political order.
- **Robert Mondi (1980)** – *Σκηπτοῦχοι βασιλεῖς: An Argument for Divine Kingship in Early Greece*. <https://www.jstor.org/stable/26308130> – **Theme 1:** Argues for **divine kingship in early Greece**, demonstrating how Greek myth and ritual supported the idea of kings as divinely sanctioned leaders.
- **Robert A. Segal (2002)** – *Myth and Politics: A Response to Robert Ellwood*. <https://www.jstor.org/stable/1466526> – **Theme 1:** A theoretical discussion on **myth's political function**, explaining how myths lend authority to social institutions and ideas (general framework for myth justifying societal norms).

Myth as Reflection of Socio-Political and Cultural Practices

- **Robert Deliège (1993)** – *The Myths of Origin of the Indian Untouchables*. <https://www.jstor.org/stable/2804238> – **Theme 2:** Examines Indian caste-origin myths, showing how mythic narratives reflect and reinforce the **caste system and dharma** in Hindu society (ancient socio-cultural hierarchy explained through myth).
- **Katja Goebs & John Baines (2018)** – *Functions and Uses of Egyptian Myth*. <https://www.jstor.org/stable/26976856> – **Theme 2:** Discusses how myth operated in ancient Egypt, including the **ideology of kingship**. It illustrates myths as mirrors of **Egyptian socio-political order** (e.g. pharaoh's divine role and cultural practices grounded in mythic concepts).

Myth in Religious and Philosophical Discourse

- **Ludwig Edelstein (1949)** – *The Function of the Myth in Plato's Philosophy*. <https://www.jstor.org/stable/2707185> – **Theme 3:** Analyzes **Plato's use of myth** in his philosophical works, showing how myths serve as foundations for ethical lessons and philosophical ideas (myth employed as a pedagogical tool for conveying moral and metaphysical concepts).
- **Julia Annas (1982)** – *Plato's Myths of Judgement*. <https://www.jstor.org/stable/4182147> – **Theme 3:** Focuses on Plato's eschatological myths (e.g. Myth of Er), explaining their role in **religious/philosophical discourse**. This source highlights how myth underpins Plato's ethical arguments about the soul, virtue, and justice in the afterlife.

Myth as Appropriation of Religious and Political Values

- **W. G. Lambert (1984)** – *Studies in Marduk*. <https://www.jstor.org/stable/618314> – **Theme 4:** Details the **rise of Marduk** in Mesopotamia, demonstrating how Babylonian rulers elevated Marduk's myth (e.g. in the *Enūma Eliš* creation epic) to appropriate religious authority and justify **Babylon's political dominance** in the pantheon and empire.
 - **Richard F. Bense (2008)** – *Valor and Valkyries: Why the State Needs Valhalla*. <https://www.jstor.org/stable/40213487> – **Theme 4:** Explores the Norse **Valhalla warrior myth** and its political usage. It shows how Viking/Medieval states appropriated this myth of glorious afterlife for warriors to instill **military values and loyalty**, aligning religious belief with political and military objectives.
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